THE BATTLE OF THE DARDANELLES

In January 1915 the Royal Navy drew up plans for an ambitious operation designed to drive Ottoman Turkey out of the war. British and French warships would force a passage through the Dardanelles into the Sea of Marmara. There they would menace the Ottoman capital Constantinople with their guns, obliging the Turks to surrender.

The passage through the Dardanelles was blocked by minefields covered by the batteries of a series of forts and mobile howitzers. Admiral Sackville Carden began the naval attack on these defenses on February 19. He had a substantial force of British and French battleships at his disposal, although most of these were aging pre-dreadnoughts whose heavy guns proved far less effective against shore batteries than had been anticipated. However, the greatest weakness of the Allied forces was a lack of efficient minesweepers.

On February 25 the Turks abandoned the forts at the entrance to the strait, but Carden made no further progress. Through the first two weeks of March the inner forts were shelled almost daily, but the minefields remained uncleared and the navy began taking casualties.

FORCING THE STRAIT

With Carden in poor health, it was Admiral John de Robeck who assumed command for the decisive bid to force the straits on March 18. Almost the entire force of heavy warships advanced in three lines, one of them consisting of four French pre-dreadnoughts under Rear Admiral Emile Guépratte.

Opening around 11:00 a.m. the exchange of fire between sea and shore was intense. Ordered forward to engage the forts at close range, the French ships took heavy punishment, especially *Gaulois,* which ran aground to avoid sinking. At 2:00 p.m. de Robeck ordered the French to withdraw so he could bring other ships forward to cover the mineclearing. As the French wheeled right, *Bouvet* struck a mine and quickly sank. Only 35 of the 674 crew were saved. One disaster followed another. The battlecruiser *Inflexible* was next to hit a mine, withdrawing with a heavy list. Then it was the turn of *Irresistible* and *Ocean*; both were immobilized by mines and abandoned. With night approaching, de Robeck signaled for all the ships to retire. There was no further attempt to force a passage through the straits. Instead it was decided to land troops at Gallipoli—an operation that was to prove an even more costly failure.



Amphora from HMS Implacable
The *Implacable* supported the troop landings at Gallipoli—part of the failed attempt to open the straits to British and French warships.

